arrangements, delays and restoration work also entailed an additional investment of nearly Rs 100 crore.

Meanwhile, the opposition intensified the agitation, which turned violent. Open acts of aggression and intimidation of the workforce at the site became commonplace. The agitators breached the compound walls at many places. Country-made bombs were lobbed into the factory location. The agitated farmers also moved the court to scrap the project. By 2008, the problems had mounted and threatened to derail the project.

Ratan was overwhelmed. In January 2008, he wrote an anguished letter to Chief Minister Bhattacharjee to salvage the project and suggested a crisis management plan. His frustration was evident in the letter he sent: 'While this may sound dramatic, I am raising this because the Singur site will have the largest single industrial investment in terms of sophisticated equipment that the State would have seen in several years. Damage and/or disruption to the transport and erection of this equipment on site will cause an enormous financial loss and a huge delay in time.'

But the government was incapable of extricating the project from the quagmire. It was not like the other states where the Tatas had set up industries.

In the midst of all the bad news, there was some welcome relief for Tata Motors. In January 2008, the Kolkata High Court ruled in favour of the state government in a writ petition that was filed as a PIL. The PIL had challenged the acquisition on the ground that it would destroy the 'livelihood of 10,000 agricultural households', ruining 'fertile lands'.

The court upheld the legality of the acquisition on the ground that 'substantial amounts have already been paid by way of compensation', and that it was made for 'public purpose'. An appeal to the Supreme Court challenging the high court order also failed at the time—although in 2016, the apex court did declare the acquisition illegal.

The political stand-off attracted national and international media attention for the wrong reasons. The *Financial Times* described Ratan as being in 'battle with farmers'.

Bhattacharjee was unable to win the political battle. A spirited Banerjee positioned herself as the saviour and protector of farmers' rights and fought ferociously. She demanded the return of the lands compulsorily taken from the farmers.